

■ Flashbulb Memory

■ What is it?

Emotional or surprising moments stick like snapshots in memory.

Flashbulb memories are highly detailed, vivid, and long-lasting memories of shocking or emotional events—like a mental photograph.

For example, many people remember exactly where they were when they first heard about the **2004 Tsunami tragedy**.

■■ History

The term **Flashbulb Memory** was introduced in 1977 by psychologists **Roger Brown and James Kulik**.

They found that strong emotions—like shock, joy, or fear—can “freeze” a moment into memory, making it feel clear and unforgettable, even if the details aren’t always accurate.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- Emotional intensity triggers the brain's **amygdala**, which strengthens memory encoding.
- These memories feel real and detailed but can include distortions.
- In UX, emotional highs (delight) or lows (frustration) often become **lasting memories** that shape how users see a product long-term.

■■ Why It Matters

Flashbulb memories can:

- Shape strong first impressions
- Drive **brand loyalty** or long-term avoidance
- Let single bad moments overshadow many good ones
- Bias user testing (because extreme moments dominate feedback)

■ How to Apply It

- **Create positive peaks** → surprise rewards, smooth onboarding.
- **Reduce negative flashpoints** → avoid bugs during first-time use.
- **Add delight** → animations, sounds, or celebratory microinteractions.
- **Design emotional moments** → focus on memories, not just usability.

■ Theory in Action

- **Airbnb (2023)** let users book a real-life *Barbie DreamHouse*, tapping into childhood nostalgia and creating unforgettable memories.
- **Disney park entrances** are designed to inspire awe instantly, ensuring visitors form positive flashbulb memories from the start.

■ Final Thought

People don't just remember what your product did—they remember how it made them **feel**.

Design with emotion in mind, because **moments become memories**—and those memories decide if users return or leave.